

Climax: Dance and Delirium

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PSYC3398 - Cognition Through Film

May 9th, 2025

Birth is a unique opportunity, Death is an extraordinary experience. Gaspar Noé's French film *Climax* (2018) exists at the intersection of visceral horror, experimental cinema, and dance expression, creating an immersive psychological experience that deliberately disintegrates the boundaries between performers and audience. Set in an abandoned school building in the mid-1990s, the film chronicles a French dance troupe's celebration that transforms into a nightmarish descent into madness after they unknowingly consume sangria laced with LSD. Through its technical choices and narrative structure, *Climax* interrogates the relationship between collective identity and individual psyche, exploring how social cohesion collapses under extreme psychological pressure.

Unlike traditional narrative cinema, *Climax* employs an unconventional structure that mirrors the psychological journey of intoxication — beginning with clarity and control before spiraling into fragmentation and chaos. The film establishes its characters through a series of interviews played on a television screen, followed by an elaborate dance sequence demonstrating their artistic union. These opening segments establish both individual personalities and collective harmony before the film systematically deconstructs both. What follows is a series of increasingly disturbing vignettes as the dancers confront their darkest impulses and fears in a drug-induced psychosis.

At the precise center of this narrative arc lies a pivotal nine-minute dance sequence that serves as the fulcrum upon which the entire film balances — marking the exact moment when celebration transforms into nightmare, when unity fractures into isolation, and when control surrenders to chaos. This scene, filmed predominantly from an overhead perspective between the 38-minute and 47-minute

marks, visually and emotionally encapsulates the film's central themes while employing specific cinematic techniques that cognitively engage the viewer in the characters' psychological deterioration.

The scene in question (38:00-47:00) occupies the film's midpoint and represents the critical transition between the movie's two distinct halves: the establishment of the dance troupe's dynamics and personalities in the first half, very much a musical comedy (especially in the native tongue, according to my friend), and their descent into psychological horror in the second. Prior to this sequence, we've been introduced to each character through their audition interviews and through intimate conversations during the party's early stages, establishing their relationships, desires, and tensions. The dancers have already consumed the LSD-spiked sangria but are only beginning to feel its effects as the sequence begins.

The scene opens at the 38-minute mark with a shot of the DJ booth, where the music that will drive the sequence begins. The camera then transitions to a fixed overhead position, looking directly down at a circle of dancers on a floor bathed in a murky red. The dancers themselves are dressed predominantly in black, red, and brown — colors that visually blend with the floor, creating a unified visual field where individual boundaries begin to blur. This aerial perspective remains largely static for the first six minutes of the sequence.

The dance circle follows a traditional cypher structure, with individual dancers taking turns in the center to showcase their abilities while others form the circle's perimeter. Each featured dancer demonstrates a unique style that reflects their personality as established earlier in the film. However, as the sequence progresses, several significant transformations occur.

As energy and pressure scaffold through the screen, the once orderly circle slowly loses its geometric precision, becoming increasingly asymmetrical and fragmented. This shift extends to the dancers on the perimeter, who begin interacting more intensely with one another and with the featured performer. Simultaneously, the music gradually increases in tempo, mirroring the dancers' accelerating psychological states. Physical interactions become more frequent and intimate, reflecting the lowering of social inhibitions.

At approximately the 44-minute mark, the camera cuts back briefly to the DJ booth as the music shifts, then returns to the overhead shot. However, the camera now begins a slow rotational movement, inducing a disorienting “spinning” sensation that mimics the vertigo of intoxication. By the sequence's conclusion at the 47-minute mark, several dancers have collapsed to the floor while others continue dancing with increasing erratic movements. The organized circle has completely dissolved, signaling the breakdown of social structure that will characterize the remainder of the film.

This scene serves as both culmination of the film's first half and catalyst for its second, visually representing the moment when collective harmony transforms into individual psychological chaos — the titular “climax” that precedes the descent.

Overhead Static Camera Perspective

The scene primarily employs a fixed overhead camera positioned directly above the dance floor, creating a god's-eye view that remains static for approximately six minutes before beginning a slow

rotation. This perspective flattens the three-dimensional space of the dance floor into a two-dimensional visual field, reminiscent of abstract painting or architectural blueprints.

This overhead perspective serves multiple narrative and psychological functions. First, it establishes a visual metaphor for social structure — the dance circle becomes a living organism with its own patterns and behaviors viewed from a clinical, observational distance. The dancers form a literal human circle that visually represents their social cohesion. As the drugs take effect, this geometric precision gradually deteriorates, visually representing the breakdown of social order.

The fixed nature of the shot for the first six minutes also creates a stark contrast to the handheld, subjective camera work that dominates the rest of the film. While most of *Climax* places viewers in the immediate, chaotic perspective of its characters, this sequence momentarily pulls back to an objective, omniscient view — allowing us to witness the collective dissolution from a distance before plunging back into subjective chaos.

Additionally, this perspective creates a visual flattening that reduces dancers to patterns of movement rather than individual characters, reinforcing the theme of collective identity. The identical coloring of costumes and floor further blends individuals into the visual field, suggesting the loss of personal boundaries that accompanies both extreme group experiences and psychedelic intoxication. By the end of the film, characters are entirely subsumed into the visual field dissolved into the background of the homogenizing strobe lights.

Cognitively, this technique creates a paradoxical viewing experience. The distant, objective perspective initially positions viewers as detached observers, creating emotional distance. Yet as the scene progresses, this very distance becomes increasingly uncomfortable — we witness the deterioration of order but cannot intervene or escape. The extended duration of the unbroken shot (unusual in contemporary cinema; more traditional) forces sustained attention on subtle changes, creating mounting tension through minimalism rather than rapid editing (Cutting, 2016).

The overhead view also activates different cognitive processes than eye-level perspectives. Rather than primarily engaging our social cognition, which relies heavily on facial expressions and eye contact processed by the ventral visual stream (the “what”), this perspective emphasizes pattern recognition and spatial awareness, functions largely attributed to the dorsal visual stream (the “where”) (Goodale & Milner, 1992). As viewers, we become hyper-aware of geometric relationships, symmetry breaking, and emergent patterns, aligning with Gestalt principles of perceptual organization that emphasize the perception of wholes and patterns (Wertheimer, 1938). This heightened sensitivity to visual patterns and their disruption, particularly the breaking of symmetry, mirrors the altered sensory perception often reported during psychedelic experiences.

Visual Symmetry Dissolution

The scene begins with a highly symmetrical composition, dancers arranged in a nearly perfect circle with clean, geometric framing from above. As the sequence progresses, this visual symmetry gradually dissolves: the circle becomes irregular, dancers break formation, negative space becomes

unevenly distributed across the frame, and the previously distinct boundary between circle perimeter and center becomes blurred.

This progressive breakdown of visual symmetry functions as a direct visual metaphor for the film's central theme: the dissolution of social order and psychological stability under extreme pressure. Symmetry in visual composition typically conveys harmony, balance, and control — its gradual erosion visually represents the deterioration of these qualities within the narrative.

The technique also serves a character development function. Initially, the dancers maintain their assigned roles (circle member or featured soloist), reflecting the established social hierarchy of the troupe. As visual symmetry breaks down, these roles become increasingly fluid: some dancers linger in the spotlight beyond their turn, others never return to the circle after their solo, while several begin to join the soloist in the center, creating visual evidence of the social boundaries collapsing.

Additionally, the symmetry dissolution functions narratively as foreshadowing. The breakdown of visual order in this scene prefigures the complete collapse of social norms and behaviors that will characterize the film's second half. Viewers witness in visual terms what will soon manifest in behavioral terms — making this technique a form of visual prologue to the horror that follows.

The gradual dissolution of symmetry creates a specific cognitive effect in viewers related to what neuroscientists call “prediction error.” The human brain constantly generates predictions about visual patterns and experiences discomfort when those predictions are violated (Sedley et al., 2016). By

establishing and then slowly disrupting symmetry, Noé creates increasing levels of prediction error, generating unconscious visual tension.

Our visual cognition is particularly attuned to symmetry — studies show that symmetrical compositions are processed more efficiently by the visual cortex and generally perceived as more pleasing (Bertamini et al., 2019). By gradually disrupting this symmetry, the scene creates escalating visual cognitive load, requiring more neural resources to process the increasingly complex visual field (Reber et al., 2004). This mimics the cognitive overload experienced during psychedelic states, where normal perceptual filtering mechanisms become impaired.

Furthermore, the dissolution of the circle's geometric precision may create visual tension in viewers. Research suggests humans generally display a cognitive preference for order over chaos in visual stimuli (Bar & Neta, 2006). As the orderly circle transforms into a chaotic arrangement, it may contribute to feelings of discomfort or unease in viewers, as our perceptual systems typically process ordered, symmetrical information more readily than disordered arrangements (Van Geert, & Wagemans, 2021).

Progressive Tempo Manipulation

Throughout the six-minute sequence, the techno music that drives the dancers undergoes a subtle but persistent acceleration in tempo. This acceleration is gradual enough to be almost subliminal at first but becomes increasingly apparent as the scene progresses. Combined with this tempo shift is a progressive intensification of the music's rhythmic complexity and volume.

This auditory technique serves as a direct sensory parallel to the pharmacokinetics of LSD, the gradual onset and intensification of the drug's effects. Just as the dancers are experiencing an accelerating psychological state as the LSD takes effect, viewers experience an accelerating auditory environment that neurologically influences our perception of time and tension.

The music functions as more than soundtrack; it becomes a narrative device that structures the psychological progression of the scene. The initial steady beat establishes order and control — the dancers move in harmony with its predictable rhythm. As the tempo subtly increases, this predictability is challenged, forcing both dancers and viewers to constantly recalibrate their expectations. This mirrors the cognitive disorientation of psychedelic experiences, where stable perceptual frameworks become increasingly unreliable.

Furthermore, the music serves as a binding agent between the otherwise isolated dancers. Even as their movements become increasingly individualistic, they remain connected through their shared response to the music, creating a tension between collective experience and individual interpretation that lies at the heart of the film's themes.

The accelerating tempo creates a physiological response in viewers. Studies have demonstrated that musical tempo directly influences heart rate, breathing patterns, and arousal levels (Lundqvist et al., 2009; Salimpoor et al., 2011). As the music speeds up, viewers may experience increased tension and physical arousal without necessarily being conscious of why. This creates a bodily experience of anxiety that precedes cognitive recognition — we feel the discomfort before we understand its source (Juslin & Västfjäll, 2008).

The gradual nature of this acceleration also creates a form of perceptual manipulation. Just as the dancers don't immediately realize they've been drugged, viewers may not initially register the tempo change, creating a subliminal sense of disorientation (Dehaene et al., 2006). This technique effectively places viewers in a parallel psychological position to the characters, experiencing a gradual destabilization of our perceptual framework, akin to the difficulty in detecting slow changes in our environment (Simons & Chabris, 1999).

The music also establishes what neuroscientists call “entrainment”— the tendency of biological rhythms to synchronize with external rhythms (Phillips-Silver et al., 2010). As viewers, our neural oscillations begin to synchronize with the music's beat (Nozaradan et al., 2011), creating a form of physiological involvement with the scene that transcends intellectual engagement. When this steady rhythm begins to accelerate and destabilize, it creates a form of cognitive dissonance or violated expectation (Huron, 2006) that mirrors the characters' experience.

QALMRI

The phenomenon of neural entrainment described by Nozaradan et al. (2011) provides a neurophysiological basis for understanding how the progressive tempo manipulation in *Climax* affects viewers on a cognitive level. Nozaradan and colleagues conducted a study to directly investigate neural entrainment to musical beat and meter, which is particularly relevant to understanding the cognitive effects of the accelerating techno music in the film's pivotal scene.

Question: Can neural entrainment to musical beat and meter be captured directly in the human electroencephalogram (EEG) as a steady-state evoked potential?

Alternative Hypotheses: The researchers hypothesized that (1) a perceived beat would elicit a sustained periodic EEG response at the beat frequency, and (2) the mental imagery of a specific meter (binary or ternary) would elicit additional responses at the corresponding metric frequencies.

Logic: If neural populations actually entrain to beat and meter frequencies as proposed by the resonance theory, then this should be observable as steady-state evoked potentials at the specific frequencies of the beat and imagined meter.

Method: Eight musically experienced participants listened to a sound stimulus with a 2.4 Hz beat. In different conditions, they either passively listened to the beat (control condition) or mentally imposed either a binary meter (1.2 Hz) or ternary meter (0.8 Hz) onto the beat. EEG was recorded from 64 electrodes, and frequency analysis was performed to identify steady-state evoked potentials at the frequencies of interest.

Results: The researchers found that:

1. In all conditions, the beat elicited a clear steady-state evoked potential at 2.4 Hz.
2. In the binary meter condition, an additional steady-state response emerged at 1.2 Hz ($f/2$).
3. In the ternary meter condition, additional responses emerged at 0.8 Hz ($f/3$) and 1.6 Hz.

Inferences: These findings provide direct evidence that neural populations entrain not only to the perceived beat in music but also to mentally imposed metric structures. This neural entrainment represents the mechanism through which rhythmic sound patterns can modulate attention, expectation, and cognitive processing over time.

The gradual tempo acceleration in *Climax*'s dance sequence thus has cognitively effective implications. As Nozaradan et al. demonstrated, our neural oscillations naturally synchronize with musical beats, creating a form of physiological connection to the rhythm. When Noé gradually accelerates the tempo during the scene, he is effectively manipulating the viewers' neural entrainment patterns, forcing continuous neurological recalibration that mirrors the disorienting experience of the characters. Much like the dissolving visual symmetry discussed earlier, this creates a prediction error, violating established neural patterns and causing cognitive tension and increased arousal (Vuust et al., 2009). The dance sequence thus is not only a representation of the characters' drug-induced disorientation; it actively induces a parallel form of perceptual disruption in viewers through the manipulation of tempo-based neural entrainment further facilitating the merging of audience and author.

Conclusion

The pivotal dance sequence in *Climax* represents a masterful implementation of cinematic techniques that function not merely as stylistic choices but as cognitive tools that directly engage viewers' perceptual and emotional processing systems. Through the three techniques analyzed, the overhead static camera perspective, the visual symmetry dissolution, and the progressive tempo manipulation, Gaspar Noé creates a viewing experience that mimics the psychological journey of the characters, blurring the boundary between observation and participation.

This sequence serves multiple functions within the film's structure: it marks the transition point between order and chaos, provides visual manifestation of previously subtle psychological states,

and establishes a visual and cognitive foundation for the horror that follows. The careful implementation of techniques that engage both conscious and unconscious processing creates a multi-layered viewing experience that rewards both immediate emotional engagement and subsequent analytical reflection.

Climax is a wonderful example of cinema's power in manipulating perception and bringing to light that which was previously hidden — the true virtue of all Art. It represents this course quite well, showing how by understanding and deliberately engaging the cognitive mechanisms through which we process visual information, filmmakers can create experiences that transcend conventional storytelling to become experiential events that blur the boundaries between representation and reality.

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